

It's Not Just the Daytime Heat -- Scorching Nights Are Making the Heat Wave Even More Dangerous

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You know how on a hot summer day, you look forward to a cool evening? Not this week. A giant heat dome is sitting over the Midwest and East Coast, and it's not just the days that are boiling the nights are staying super warm, too. In places like Washington, D.C., and Philadelphia, temperatures are still in the 80s even after the sun goes down. That's like trying to sleep in a warm bath!

Experts say this is a big problem. Our bodies need cooler nights to rest and recover from the heat. When it stays hot all night, the risk of **heat exhaustion** and **heat stroke** goes way up, especially for people without **air conditioning**. Ashley Ward, a scientist who studies heat, says, "We're not getting the opportunity for recovery overnight, as we've historically seen." She says **climate change** is making this worse.

Why are nights getting hotter? The **atmosphere** is holding onto more heat, like a blanket. Plus, **climate change** is causing more **humid air**, which makes it harder for our sweat to cool us down. Even a summer rain shower might not help it can make things feel stickier!

Not everyone has AC. About 88% of U.S. homes do, but lower-income families and some communities of color are less likely to have it. Older people and those with health problems like heart disease are most at risk. If you have to be outside, take it slow, get used to the heat gradually, and drink lots of water. As one expert says, "Make sure they drink before their heat exposure and especially afterward to try to catch up." Stay cool, friends!

Word Treasure

heat exhaustion -- When your body gets too hot and you feel weak, dizzy, or sick.

heat stroke -- A dangerous condition where your body can't cool down and may damage organs.

climate change -- Long-term shifts in temperatures and weather, often caused by human activities.

humid air -- Air filled with moisture that makes it feel sticky and harder to cool off.

atmosphere -- The invisible layer of gases around Earth that traps heat.

air conditioning -- A machine system that cools indoor air, helping people stay safe in hot weather.

Background you need

Heat waves with hot nights are becoming more common due to climate change, which traps extra heat in the atmosphere. Ashley Ward (a scientist focusing on heat and health) explains that without cooler nights, the body can't recover, leading to more heat-related illnesses. Studies show that lower-income families and communities of color are often hit hardest because they may lack air conditioning.

Break it down

WHO: Residents in the U.S. Midwest and East Coast, heat scientists like Ashley Ward, and vulnerable groups like the elderly.

WHAT: Nighttime temperatures are staying dangerously high (in the 80s), preventing the body from recovering and increasing the risk of heat-related sickness.

WHERE: Cities such as Washington, D.C., and Philadelphia, which are under a giant heat dome.

WHY: Climate change is trapping more heat in the atmosphere, making humid nights that the body can't easily cool down from, and many people lack air conditioning.

Why it matters

Even at night, extreme heat can ruin your sleep and make you tired and grumpy, so it's important to find ways to stay cool before bed.

Test what you remember

1. What are nighttime temperatures like in some cities during this heat wave?

- ☐ (A) In the 70s
- ☐ (B) In the 80s
- ☐ (C) In the 90s
- ☐ (D) In the 100s

2. Why are hot nights dangerous?

- ☐ (A) It's harder to see
- ☐ (B) Bodies need cooler nights to rest and recover
- ☐ (C) More mosquitoes
- ☐ (D) It causes storms

3. Who is Ashley Ward?

- ☐ (A) A soccer player
- ☐ (B) A scientist who studies heat
- ☐ (C) A weather reporter
- ☐ (D) A coach

4. What does climate change make worse?

- ☐ (A) Cold snaps
- ☐ (B) Heat waves and hotter nights
- ☐ (C) Snowstorms
- ☐ (D) Earthquakes

5. What percentage of U.S. homes have air conditioning?

- ☐ (A) 50%
- ☐ (B) 75%
- ☐ (C) 88%
- ☐ (D) 95%

6. Who is most at risk from extreme heat?

- ☐ (A) Teenagers
- ☐ (B) Older people and those with heart disease
- ☐ (C) Babies
- ☐ (D) People with pets

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Public health experts:** They emphasize that hot nights are a hidden danger because people think they are safe, but the body needs cooler temperatures to recover.
- 2. Low-income families:** They may not be able to afford air conditioning, so hot nights can be a serious health risk, and community cooling centers are essential for them.
- 3. City planners:** They need to think about opening cooling centers and planting more trees to lower temperatures in neighborhoods, especially in areas with less green space.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):